



MSCA POSTDOCTORAL FELLOWSHIP · APPLICANT EXPERIENCE

FAR-SIDS

Foreign Aid, Remittances, and Wellbeing in Small Island Developing States

Dr Roxane de Waegh

Islands and Small States Institute, University of Malta

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The FAR-SIDS project

FAR-SIDS examines how foreign aid and remittances interact to support livelihoods and wellbeing in three small island developing states:

Jamaica, Tonga and Comoros.

It employs a mixed methods design, combining ethnographic fieldwork with an adapted CRiSTAL tool, household surveys, and ARDL econometric modelling, framed by the revised Sustainable Livelihoods Framework.

This presentation focuses on the proposal development process.

3

case study
islands

24

months of
funded research

3

regions: Caribbean,
Pacific, Indian Ocean

Selecting a supervisor and host institution

An existing scholarly connection that developed into a fellowship application

1 Origin

Dr Stefano Moncada examined my PhD defence in February 2024. That scholarly connection led to the idea of preparing a fellowship application together.

2 Supervisor

Dr Stefano Moncada, Director of ISSI, was my supervisor and main point of contact throughout the process.

3 Host

The Islands and Small States Institute at the University of Malta specialises in SIDS and small states research, with strong standing in the field. A close thematic fit.

4 Rationale

My doctoral work on Pacific island resilience aligned closely with the host institution's areas of expertise.

The proposal development process

Developed across mid-2024, alongside full-time employment, ahead of the 11 September deadline



How the writing worked

Highly iterative. The idea went through many rounds at the ideation stage, and every section was redrafted repeatedly.

Researcher, Roxane de Waegh. Led the drafting and the scientific development of the proposal.

Supervisor, Dr Moncada. Provided strategic direction and feedback, and made introductions, including in-country contacts for the secondment phase.

Additional support and guidance

MSCA PF Masterclass

A full-day masterclass led by Peter Sheard, a European Commission evaluator (15 May 2024), clarified how proposals are scored (50/30/20) and the value of clear, measurable objectives and a coherent project narrative.

Applying the guidance

A question I raised during the session, on the competitiveness of exploratory, constructivist grounded theory designs, prompted advice to adopt a more focused, objective-led approach, which informed how the proposal was framed.

External review, via HIPAS

Dr Moncada secured a HIPAS award (a Xjenza Malta scheme) to engage iKonsulting (Katia Insogna), an independent Horizon Europe consultant, who evaluated the draft against the MSCA criteria before submission.

Supervisor and partners

Ongoing guidance from my supervisor, Dr Moncada, alongside input from in-country research partners in Tonga, Dr Semisi Taumoepeau and Siulua Tokilupe Latu.

Reflections: strengths and challenges

What worked well

- Alignment between my background and the host institution's expertise
- A clearly defined research gap: the under-examined aid and remittance nexus in SIDS
- An independent review received with time to respond
- A supportive and responsive supervisor

Principal challenges

- Becoming familiar with the demanding MSCA proposal format
- Developing a methodology beyond my prior expertise: econometric (ARDL) modelling, where my background was qualitative and ethnographic
- A compressed timeline alongside full-time work

Response. The masterclass and external review built my grasp of the format, and the new quantitative methods were deliberately woven into the project's training plan.

Tips for a strong MSCA proposal

- 1 Start early and expect to iterate.** The idea and every section go through many rounds.
- 2 Anchor it in a clear narrative.** A genuine, well-evidenced gap, told as a coherent story.
- 3 Map closely to the evaluation criteria.** Excellence, impact, implementation, with measurable objectives.
- 4 Get the evaluator's view early.** A masterclass and an independent external review, in time to act on them.
- 5 Be willing to stretch your methods.** Work beyond your comfort zone to develop an innovative methodology.



Anticipated impact and what comes next

- The fellowship builds my independence as a researcher and adds new quantitative and mixed methods skills, within the Horizon Europe ecosystem.
- Short term: a research position in island and rural development studies, and a foundation for future research funding.
- Longer term: a leadership, tenure-track role in rural development in island contexts, for example at ISSI, with high-impact publications.
- A non-academic pathway also opens up: development finance roles, such as at IFAD or UNCDF, bridging digital finance and rural development.

In summary

The journey from idea to submission, at a glance

Choosing supervisor and host

Dr Moncada examined my PhD; ISSI specialises in SIDS research, a close thematic match.

Proposal writing process

Iterative and section by section, over the New Zealand winter of 2024 alongside full-time work.

Working with my supervisor

Dr Moncada gave direction, feedback and contacts; a HIPAS-funded iKonsulting review and a masterclass added the evaluator's view.

Time required

Roughly three months, with the, most intensive work completed in the final weeks.

Tips for a strong proposal

Start early and iterate; build a clear narrative and gap; map to the criteria; seek the evaluator's view early; stretch your methods.

Most difficult part

The demanding MSCA format, building a methodology beyond my qualitative background, and keeping the project feasible while maintaining ambitious goals.

Career impact and next step

Research independence within Horizon Europe, toward a leadership role in island and rural development.

Thank you